Amplifying and prefiguring alternative economies through designing in thick presents

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This workshop turns to economics as the central dimension of interconnected climate change and social injustice. It asks how design can bring agency, imagination and anticipation to reconfiguring, decentralising, demystifying and diversifying economies. It presents four bodies of work which are in dialogue with macroeconomics. Each of them attempts to foreground local relationships between people, land and other species in order to support micro level touchpoints to governance: where and how do we make economy through design that can anticipate authentic needs rather than market desires?

Whereas there are uncertainties in how to tackle interconnected crises of human, more-than-human and planetary health and survival, science is clear that deep change is needed. Some have already had their livelihoods destroyed and thereby futures nullified, whereas for others it is happening as we write and yet others can pretend that they can avoid grave threats to continued flourishing.

One way for design researchers and practitioners to take the planetary calls for changed human imprint seriously, is to engage with how economy is understood and performed. Such endeavour seems to require a break with the progressivist understanding of linear development of stepping onto the next step in a ladder (Gan et al 2017) where futuring is oblivious of what has previously sustained ecosystems. It is particularly important when recognising that the economic link to continuously prolific design production, usage and littering has left devastating and toxic marks in the land that human and other species survival is hinging on.

This session gathers four design research projects into a conversation that focuses on design as world-making in thick presents (Jönsson et al 2021) through heterodox economies (Boehnert 2018). They turn away from the combination of design and dominant GDP-growth which materialize as the creation of desires for new designs to be sold on the market.

Rather, these four design research projects turn towards the world as one household (Gibson 2015) where economy and ecology are interdependent (Gibson-Graham and Miller 2015). The projects have three things in common: 1. They amplify existing diverse economies where it is already present, 2. they prefigure alternative economies where they are, as of now, not yet anchored and, 3. they do so by working in a thick present of ancestral wisdom and local transdisciplinary knowledge for liveable futures.

Contributions of each of the curators

The four projects gather around trying to answer questions of the world with the pursuit of contributing to flourishing livelihoods. Whereas many design projects answer within the economic paradigm of more and new, these try out methods and practices that ventures into transformative change, foregrounding home ecologics (Tham et al 2019), un/making (Lindström and Ståhl 2019), householding (Ståhl and Keune 2025), community economies in ecosystems (Elzenbaumer et al 2025), care (Lindström and Ståhl 2019, Jönsson et al 2019), repair, composting (Lindström and Ståhl 2020), and letting go (Coops et al 2023). These all relate to the common root of inseparable ecology and economy in oikos. This conversation thus ventures into practices where design research and projects usually do not explicitly operate with change-work: to economy.

In the Italian Alps, La Foresta works with keeping historical knowledge alive when it comes to commoning of land as well as in the centrally placed train station in Rovereto (Elzenbaumer and Mammana 2024). This is a practice of governance and ongoing negotiations of communal resources.

The Earth Logic Design Agency focuses on Earth logic cultural entrepreneurship (Ståhl and Tham 2026) that highlights agency through design and self-governance in various organizational forms.

Holding Surplus House focuses on feminist ecological economic models such as householding (Ståhl 2025), with a particular focus on participatory budgeting on municipal level where the public gathers around joint decision-making and governance for an investment in the local community (Olofsdotter Bergström and Ståhl forthcoming 2026).

Design after Progress (DaP) focuses on design circles related to the doughnut economics model in a rural municipality. This design research work builds on participatory design legacies of strengthening publics in being involved in decision-making. However, the decision-making in focus was not on immediate decisions in the local government, but on long-term capacity building to be involved in creating hopeful futures through noticing, imagining and practicing everyday hope (Jackson 2023). The circles invited both the members of the public and municipal employees - who met on a final occasion.

Format being proposed

The session will unfold as a patchworking across the core questions of governance, future- and world-making in the four projects and researchers, each offering a ‘patch’ of verbal and visual questions, dilemmas, and agencies on the floor. After this first round, the audience will be invited to add patches from their experience of working across design and heterodox economies.

In the rest of the workshop, we collaboratively make sense of the emerging patchwork: which stories does it tell, and which stories may be missing? The session will result in a thickening of an emergent area of design and economies, and the visual documentation of the patchwork.

The session requires seating (chairs/cushions) in a circle with floor space for the patchwork.

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